Meanwhile, the Kohistani tribesmen were pouring in; within forty-eight hours, some 20,000 Tajiks had gathered to besiege Pottinger and his Gurkhas in their unfinished barracks. ‘It seemed indeed as though the whole male population of the country had assembled against us,’ wrote Pottinger’s Dublin-born colleague Lieutenant John Haughton.[41] The following day, the besiegers took the neighbouring fort, which overlooked the barracks, ‘and shots began to drop into the interior of our square’. Before long Pottinger had been badly wounded with a musket ball in his thigh and his military commander, Captain Christopher Codrington, had been mortally wounded in the chest.

In the days that followed, the defenders grew desperate. ‘[The last of our] water was served out to the fighting men only,’ reported Haughton, ‘about half a tea cup full to each man, and much of this was mere mud . . . Many sucked raw [sheep’s] flesh to assuage their thirst. Fighting is at all times dry work, but fighting without water is nearly impossible. The misery was great . . . Soon, our voices were hoarse, our lips were cracked, our faces begrimed with dust and smoke, and our eyes bloodshot.’ By the end of the week, the whole garrison was beginning to hallucinate. ‘About midday,’ wrote Haughton,

> it was announced to me that a body of men were visible coming from the direction of Kabul. I at once went out to look, and saw them sure enough; but were they the relief long expected or enemies? Relief certainly. I could make them out distinctly with a telescope. The foremost were horsemen, our own 5th Cavalry, a fact rendered certain by their white headdresses. We congratulated one another, and tears of joy streamed from my eyes; but alas! It soon appeared we were deceived. The fantastic play of mirage had so acted on a herd of cattle grazing, as entirely to deceive us.[42]

It was a similar story all over eastern Afghanistan. Overnight, every village turned hostile.

In the Khyber Pass, the British picket at Peshbulaq was attacked and the troops forced to fall back to Peshawar.[43] South of Kabul, on 3 November, a small party of sepoys under Captain Crawford was marching a group of captured Afghan rebel chiefs from Kandahar to Ghazni. ‘We marched all night, and by daybreak we reached Mooshky,’ remembered one of the sepoys, Himat Baniah, when questioned during his subsequent court martial.